

ULTIMATE AUDIO BUYING CHEAT-SHEET

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HEADPHONES AND EARPHONES

When shopping for headphones in today's saturated audio market, it's crucial to navigate through the hype and make informed choices. Not all products are what they seem, and understanding certain aspects can save you from overspending on features you might not need. Here are some tips and cautions for selecting the right headphones or earphones:

1 Higher is not always better

When choosing headphones, the number of drivers isn't always indicative of better sound quality. Sound frequencies are categorised into lows, mids, and highs, each with its own vibration pattern produced by the driver.

Earphones with multiple drivers distribute the workload among them. The key is precise tuning, ensuring

each driver accurately handles its designated frequency range.

Without proper tuning, you might get loud but inaccurate audio. To determine this, test earphones with a frequency sweep covering the full audio spectrum (20Hz to 20,000kHz).

2 Tuning matters the most

Tuning involves calibrating drivers to emphasise specific frequencies. Different manufacturers may tune their drivers to prioritise certain aspects of sound, leading to varied sound signatures. For example, some headphones focus on boosting bass, while others create a V-shaped sound with enhanced lows and highs.

Even drivers with the same specs can sound different if not precisely tuned. Studio-grade and consumer-grade headphones from the same brand may have distinct sound signatures. Your preference for sound should guide your choice. Everyone has a different taste, and you should know yours.

3 The CODECs

Examining headphone specifications, you'll come across CODECs that dictate signal quality when transmitting audio via Bluetooth. Various CODECs exist, with SBC being the most common. It's basic and

energy-efficient but sacrifices audio quality. In noisy environments, without noise cancellation or with poorly tuned headphones, the quality difference is less noticeable. Consider factors like streaming service quality, smartphone capabilities, and your headphone or earphone performance.

For wired audio, your device's output port capabilities are crucial. Modern mobile devices lacking a headphone jack may require an external USB DAC for lossless audio. Additional hardware considerations apply to PCs. To guide you better through the world of audio CODECs, on the right, there are brief descriptions of some popular CODECs that are seen in headphones and earphones these days.

SOUNDBARS AND SPEAKERS

When you are out looking for a good soundbar or speakers, the budget becomes one of the first things that you need to lock down.

This is because due to the evolution of technology, and the way it has made its way down the price brackets, you can get all that you would need for as low as 15K. However, the same features would also be present in a much more expensive alternative. So, with that aside, let's look at some of the important things that you need to consider and lock down when buying a soundbar or a speaker –

1 Sound is king

If you get a feature-laden product that sounds bad, then you are essentially losing out on all your hard-earned money. So, I would recommend that you ensure that every audio product that you buy, especially a

